former health minister’s choice of product to endorse and its timing was problematic.

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Through the month of May, several countries were sending various kinds of medical supplies in aid to India, including China, with whom we had just successfully concluded border disengagement talks. In our hour of crisis, many nations stood with us, as we did in theirs. Several sections of the media once again reported this as a dent on the prime minister’s vision of a self-reliant India, completely undercutting the severity of the catastrophe. Little did they know that just a few months later, several other countries and their healthcare systems would be equally overwhelmed as ours as the Delta variant would rage in their countries. In fact, when Indonesia[34] and Bangladesh[35] became victims to intense surges of infections just months after our second wave, they too ran out of oxygen and we extended relief by sending them timely oxygen and concentrators.

As the authorities tried to steer the country out of the virus’ grip, the mood in the PMO was also sombre. Every day brought with it several new challenges which needed to be resolved because millions of lives depended on the solution. At a later date, an advisor to the prime minister would recount, ‘During the second wave, we were all coming to work, physically in the office. We could have worked from home, since we were holding all meetings virtually anyway. But none of us could go back home and get a full night’s peaceful sleep because lives depended on us. We’d be in adjoining chambers, but we’d still hold virtual meetings, considering how bad the situation was in terms of the spread of the virus.’

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Enthused by the noise that the oxygen shortage episode created coupled with his ambitions to become a national political heavyweight, Kejriwal raked up several issues, many of them seeming headline-grabbing versus fact-based. Some of them hurt the country so severely that our Foreign Service officers had to rush to control the damage. On 18 May, he had tweeted, ‘The new variant of COVID-19 in Singapore is said to be very damaging for children. This can come to India in the form of a third wave. I appeal to the Centre to: Stop all flights to and from Singapore immediately,